

Waiting List

Policy: When funds are insufficient to support Colorado WIC Program's active enrollment, waitlist procedures must be activated. The State agency determines when to activate waiting lists and which participant priorities to place on a waiting list.

Regulation: CFR 246.7 (e)(4), 246.7(f)(1), FNS Instruction 803-6 Rev. 1

Procedure/Additional Guidance:

A waiting list is a list of individuals who have expressed interest in receiving WIC benefits and who are likely to be served when caseload slots become available. The waiting list process ensures that WIC services are provided to participants with the highest nutritional risk (lowest priority). The decision regarding which priorities to place on waiting lists is based on available funding and estimates of the cost to provide WIC services to groups of participants of identical priority. The State agency notifies the local WIC agencies in writing of the need for waiting lists, the type of waiting list, which priorities to place on the waiting list, and the implementation date.

Type of Waiting Lists

Access to the Clinic Services Administration>Waiting List panel is available to selected State Office staff only. On this panel, the State Office user defines the effective date of the waiting list and the specific participant categories and priorities that will be eligible for the waiting list. There are two types of waiting lists – certified and uncertified. When waiting list status is activated, the State Agency will designate whether to implement one or both types:

- **Uncertified waiting lists** include those applicants who expressed interest in applying for the WIC Program but have not been screened. These applicants must be placed on the list based on their highest potential priority (Priority 1 for pregnant and breastfeeding women and infants, Priority 3 for children and Priority 4 for postpartum women). Uncertified waiting lists are manually recorded on a log.
- **Certified waiting lists** include applicants who have been certified eligible through screening, but whose priority is not currently being served. Certified waiting lists will be created by the computer system after the certification information has been entered into the computer. The lists will be grouped by priority.

Documentation

Each local agency must keep a waiting list of all individuals who express interest in receiving WIC benefits, either in person or by telephone. Each local agency will maintain the following data elements for each applicant entered in Compass:

- The applicant's name
- Address and/or phone number
- Applicant status (pregnant, breastfeeding, age of applicant, etc.)
- The date the applicant was placed on the waiting list.

Notifying Applicants & Participants

The local agency WIC user must:

- Screen every interested applicant for eligibility and priority.
- Inform applicants regarding the need for a waiting list. Notify applicants of their placement on a waiting list on the day of initial contact.
- Explain that the local program will serve highest priority applicants first when funding and caseloads are limited and that WIC services will be extended to as many eligible participants as possible.
- Once an applicant is on the waiting list, encourage them to contact the local program with address changes or new telephone numbers to facilitate future appointment scheduling.
- Refer all applicants to other health and social service agencies such as food banks, SNAP, etc.

Any individual who specifically requests to be placed on a waiting list in person must be added to the list, regardless of their qualification status.

Actively enrolled participants who fail to keep their scheduled WIC appointments and then contact the local WIC program requesting to rescheduled appointment when that local program has no appointments available may be placed on the waiting list.

Equal treatment

An applicant who has never been on WIC must have the same access to available appointment slots as a participant who is applying for a second or subsequent certification. Civil rights regulations do not allow a request for information on ethnic classification as part of waiting list procedures.

Discontinuing Waiting lists

The State WIC Office determines when waiting lists will be discontinued and will provide local WIC agencies written notification and instructions. Generally, local agencies will perform the following:

- Contact the first person on the list, either by letter or telephone and schedule them for an appointment to determine eligibility. Make it clear that this is only to complete screening and does not mean that they will be automatically certified on the program.
- Document on the waiting list that notice was given.
- If the attempt is made to contact an applicant by phone and the individual cannot be reached, a follow up letter must be sent to notify the applicant to complete the screening process. Document that the letter was sent.
- Continue down the list and contact each person.
- Applicants who respond to the notification shall complete screening to determine eligibility. Check income if data is older than 30 days. Collect anthropometric and blood work data:
 - o if not taken at time of application,
 - o is >60 days old, or
 - o does not reflect current participant category
- Drop an applicant from the list when they:
 - o do not respond to notification after 15 days from the date of the letter;
 - o miss their screening appointment;
 - o are no longer categorically eligible (i.e. child turns 5); or
 - o have completed the screening visit and determined to be either eligible or ineligible.